

RUCHIR JOSHI

The Photography Centre is a comparatively recent addition to the Victoria & Albert Museum. The seven galleries housing the V&A's photo collection make up the largest exhibition space dedicated to a permanent photo collection in the UK. As you walk into the first gallery, you are drawn into the history of the medium, with several images from the earliest decades of photography. Gradually, the exhibits pull you from the 19th century into the 20th and then into current times. As you explore this, you realise you are traversing not only the history of the medium but also the history of the world as recorded by the medium: here is the photograph as an early object, here it is in colonial albums, here is a record of protests, of revolutions and war, here it is as the controlling documentation of colonial regimes, or in the game-changing picture magazines that proliferated in America from the 1930s to the 1970s, here it is as an art object or a tool of protest.

Unsurprisingly, there is a preponderance in the collection of Western, and, among them, of male, white, Anglo-American photographers, but that changes the closer you come to our own times. Two of the contemporary photographers have roots in South Asia. Vasantha Yogananthan was born in France but has travelled extensively through India and Sri Lanka to produce one of the most brilliant series of photographs to come out of the subcontinent. *A Myth of Two Souls* finds or constructs images that take off from the Ramayana, where Yogananthan frames today's people and landscapes but with Mareecha or Luv and Kush in mind. The pictures are a small but powerful antidote to the grotesque misuses to which people in power have been putting our epics and myths.

Two nearby walls display a very different documentation of contemporary India and of people's resistance to the misuse of power. Gauri Gill, one of India's major photographers, kept visiting the farmers' protests around Delhi's borders. In the 48 images from her 2020 series *The Village on the Highway*, you see a human figure in only one frame—a man lying down in a truck, supporting his head on his hand, à la the statues of the Buddha, his figure screened by some netting. All the other photographs are of the structures put up by the farmers. Here, trucks have been turned into houses and *langars*, coolers and air-conditioners have been attached to the backs of trailers to survive the summer heat; a tractor rests under a *shamiana*, almost like another member of the family. At one level, you can connect these images to classic work from photography's past: Eugène Atget's unpeopled documentation of Paris streets comes to mind, as does the work of Bernd and Hilla Becher hanging in the adjacent gallery. At another level, Gill's work has always been about human warmth and connection, and you can see the presence of the farmers in these pictures, their caring of the elders who refused to be left out of the protests, the inventiveness of Indian *jugaad*.

Placed almost at the end of the image-journey through the galleries, it is a beautifully fitting penultimate stop, as it were, to the current display. ■

Ruchir Joshi

Photographs by AMIT PASRICHA







THE LONG VIEW
(clockwise from left) A chawl room in Mumbai; the remains of a 12th-century Chola temple in Tharangambadi, Tamil Nadu; a village home in Kashmir

of everyday life in the other half of the image. A deft placement or distortion of elements in opposing parts of the panorama is deployed to subvert the hierarchy of emphasis. The humble quarters of a chawl or a tribal hut with the family utensils displayed on shelves sweeping across the image can look as visually opulent as the living room of a palace. In another photograph, a spectator of a festive procession or bystander in a family ceremony can be as much a central subject as the eye sweeps across the scene. Often, the visuals are dislodged from a single centre of gravity and the eye floats in a delirium of experiences across the panorama. A broken temple spire lying in the sea is simultaneously dwarfed and exaggerated by the scale of human elements surrounding it.

At another level, an image can at once be a portrait as well as an architectural or even anthropological study of the space. A simple Kashmiri village home opens out into a labyrinthine maze of spaces and dimensions peopled by its residents. As the gaze moves in those personal quarters, the eye is no more a voyeur but a co-inhabitant.

If Raghubir Singh, Steve McCurry and Raghu Rai mapped the romance and emotive soul of India, Amit Pasricha is exploring that geography further, with a wider frame and expressing a more tactile experience of the Indian rasa—its rich textural, chromatic and cultural layers. Much beyond panoramas, Pasricha's images are personal travelogues of a journey into the cultural core of India—sitting in a limousine. ■

Bandeep Singh